

his dismay, the party bosses are in no mood to indulge him. The fractious state unit has no shortage of Sidhu-baiters either. His opponents are clearly enjoying his discomfiture. Sukhbir didn't lose the chance to let go a reverse-sweep: "Where is his *baraat*, who are his *baraatis*...," he asked.

Now, Punjab '22 has already seen some hasty shotgun weddings between former foes. But the BJP has also been attracting a few new, unlikely *baraatis*. On Guru Gobind Singh's 357th birth anniversary on January 9, Prime Minister Narendra Modi lobbed a feelgood sop in the air—the martyrdom day of the last guru's younger sons would be observed as Vir Bal Diwas, he said. The SGPC (Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee) didn't exactly warm to the gesture, but the PM got an ally from within the Panthic community. From Baba Harnam Singh Dhumma, chief of the Damdami Taksal—the controversial Sikh seminary once headed by Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale! Days later, Dhumma's close associate, Sikh scholar Sarchand Singh, even joined the BJP.

A day earlier, there had been another notable entrant: the grandson of late Akali icon Gurcharan Singh Tohra. Now, this is the kind of unexpected googly that may have foxed Sidhu the Batsman back in the day. For long, BJP was almost an "untouchable" in Panthic politics. To see a young Tohra in its ranks is a change it will welcome—Tohra Sr was SGPC chief for over 25 years, and the family is still respected in Panthic circles. And the Damdami Taksal...baby steps in a more ambitious strategy, perhaps? ■

PARTY LINE: *NPP*

PAN-NORTHEAST? IT'S AN IDEA

Most observers tend to view the Manipur election as a clash between the two better-known national parties: the BJP and Congress. But a regional force—and not one of Manipuri origin at that—is hoping to carve out a steady, silent route to power. Currently part of the BJP-led government in Manipur, the National People's Party (NPP) has chosen to go solo, aspiring to yank its numbers up from four to something in double digits in the 60-member House. This is part of NPP president Conrad K. Sangma's calculated design. Conrad, former Lok Sabha Speaker P.A. Sangma's son and Meghalaya CM, plans to turn the NPP into a true pan-Northeast party. That's a unique experiment in ecumenism in a region beset by inter-state, inter-ethnic rivalries. The NPP is already spreading its organisational wings across the Northeast, including in Assam. Sangma's style is to let the local units decide the narrative instead of foisting his views on them. (His only preference is the word 'tribal' be abjured; he votes for 'indigenous'.) Leading the party in Manipur is deputy CM and ex-DGP Yumnam Joykumar Singh and his Oxford-educated daughter Ratika. ■



NATIONAL FOOTPRINT DREAMS Conrad Sangma

BANDEEP SINGH



has 14 of the state's 22 districts. Dhuri also falls squarely within what's called 'Royal Punjab'—the Phulkian belt that includes the erstwhile princely estates of Patiala, Nabha, Faridkot, Jind and Malerkotla. For decades, this region remained a hotbed of Naxalism. Later, the sectarian Khalistan movement also found fertile ground here. In recent times, this was the epicentre of the farm agitation. And the instances of sacrilege that roiled Punjab also played out here. All these are live factors—the hold exerted by the erstwhile royalty (all Jat Sikh, save for Malerkotla's Pathan rulers), Communist sympathies, and a defiant Sikh identitarianism that even went against the abrogation of Article 370 and the CAA. The trading Brahmins and Baniyas, who dominate the urban centres, are often the swing voters—their influence is such that even the Akali Dal has fielded a Hindu candidate. The AAP won 16 of its 20 seats in 2017 from these parts, but this is also Amarinder Singh's backyard, as it is of the farm unions. Commoners against kings, in a way. ■